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Strategic collaboration in sports? Analyzing multiple cross-sectoral partnerships in non-profit boxing

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ABSTRACT

Rationale: To address complexities in their environment, non-profit sports clubs enter partnerships with other organizations. While partnerships between non-profit sports clubs and commercial sports providers are increasing, research into these types of partnerships has been scarce. The aim of the present study is thus to analyze cross-sectoral partnerships between sports clubs and commercial providers to explore why, how, and with which outcomes these partnerships are formed.

Research design: A case study was conducted on a non-profit boxing club entertaining several cross-sectoral partnerships. Data were collected through semi-structured interviews, documents, and an in-person survey.

Findings: The results show inconsistencies in the strategic management of partnerships. Stable partnerships were based on personal relationships and trust rather than formal arrangements.

Practical implications: To ensure stable partnerships, clubs need to communicate constantly with their partners to form strong personal relationships. Shared goals should be formulated to create partnership value.

Research contribution: The study highlights the extent of strategic collaboration in sports.

KEYWORDS

Interorganizational Relationships; Strategic Management; Competitive Advantage; Case Study

Introduction

Non-profit sports clubs are voluntary, member-based organizations that offer opportunities for sports participation in many countries (Breuer et al., 2015). They are operating in an increasingly complex and competitive environment (Koski, 2012). To reduce complexities, sports clubs are entering partnerships with other organizations (Slack et al., 2021), so-called inter-organizational relationships (IOR). While the importance of IORs has been growing in the sports market, it has also been an increasing topic of interest in sport management research (Misener et al., 2022). Several studies have investigated the formation and management of IORs in sports organizations such as non-profit sports clubs (e.g. Lefebvre et al., 2022; Misener & Doherty, 2013, 2014; Wicker et al., 2013b).

Sports clubs can collaborate with a variety of different partners. One type of collaboration that is increasing is collaboration between non-profit sports clubs and commercial sports providers (e.g. fitness centers, martial arts studios; Breuer & Feiler, 2022). These partnerships can include for example joint offering of sports programs, use of resources, or use of networks. This is especially interesting as sports clubs and commercial sports providers can be considered competitors to non-profit sports clubs as they offer similar services (Rossi et al., 2020).

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Despite offering similar services, non-profit sports clubs and commercial sports providers follow different institutional logics (for-profit vs. non-profit) (Misener & Misener, 2017). These different institutional logics could be a reason why – despite the increase over time - the overall extent of IORs between non-profit sports clubs and commercial sports providers is relatively low (Breuer & Feiler, 2022; Vos & Scheerder, 2014), which hints at challenges and obstacles in managing IORs between organizations operating in different market sectors (so-called cross-sectoral partnerships (CSP); see Waddock, 1991). These challenges can be power imbalances through different levels of resource possession, which then can lead to a decrease in trust and increasingly opportunistic behavior (Selsky & Parker, 2005).

In contrast, research in the general non-profit context has also identified several positive effects of CSPs such as access to resources and expertise, making use of diverse perspectives in terms of problem-solving, improving service provision, as well as the attraction of a more diverse target group and the initiation of social change (Selsky & Parker, 2005). As research in the specific context of collaborations between non-profit sports clubs and commercial sports providers has thus far been scarce (except for Vos & Scheerder, 2014; Wicker et al., 2013b), insights are missing what specific challenges and benefits non-profit sports clubs are experiencing in these kinds of CSPs. Moreover, it is unknown if non-profit sports clubs use and manage partnerships with commercial sports providers strategically.

The aim of the study is, therefore, to investigate CSPs between non-profit sports clubs and commercial sports providers to explore specific processes, outcomes, and challenges using a case study of a non-profit boxing club entertaining several CSPs with commercial boxing clubs. Moreover, the present study uses a strategic management perspective to investigate why non-profit sports clubs enter partnerships with commercial sports providers who are potential competitors and identify specific pitfalls and success factors in the management of these partnerships. The findings help to bridge the researcher-practitioner gap by presenting clear implications for the management of collaborations between non-profit sports clubs and commercial sports providers. The research questions guiding this study are the following:

RQ1: Why and how do non-profit sports clubs and commercial sports providers form CSPs?

RQ2: What are the outcomes of CSPs between non-profit sports clubs and commercial sports providers?

RQ3: How can CSPs between non-profit sports clubs and commercial sports providers be managed effectively?

The paper starts with an overview of relevant literature, followed by the introduction of the theoretical framework. The empirical strategy and the results of the study are presented next, followed by a discussion of findings considering theory and literature. The paper concludes with a presentation of theoretical and practical implications.

Literature Review

Systematic reviews on IORs in sports have highlighted a broad range of studies and findings in sport management research (Babiak et al., 2018; Misener et al., 2022). Several studies have investigated the general drivers of CSPs. In the context of Canadian Sports Centers, CSPs between the Sports Centers and their partners (including corporate partners) were initiated due to institutional forces and individual interest (Babiak, 2007). Moreover, previous studies have provided evidence that non-profit sports clubs enter CSPs with commercial partners to address organizational problems (Wicker et al., 2013b) and meet competitive challenges (Vos & Scheerder, 2014). However, motives in CSPs can also differ between the partners. Alexander et al. (2008) showed that in the context of a partnership between a non-profit provincial

sports organization and a public sector sports organization, motives for entering the partnership differed between necessity, efficiency, and reciprocity on the non-profit side and seeking legitimacy on the public side.

Typical challenges that have been identified in the sports context relate to structural challenges in terms of governance problems, unclear roles and responsibilities as well as the complexity and partnership forms (Babiak & Thibault, 2009). Moreover, strategic challenges have been uncovered as organizations shift between competition and collaboration (Babiak & Thibault, 2009).

When it comes to the process of implementing IORs, it has been shown that formal controls in form of clearly defined objectives, division of costs, formal contracts, and reporting structures harm the interaction between organizations and thus limit the CSP whereas informal processes and the reliance on trust between the partners increased the effectiveness of CSPs (Babiak & Thibault, 2008). Moreover, Misener and Doherty (2013) have identified trust, consistency, balance, and engagement as key relationship processes which ensure the effective implementation of IORs in sports. However, in the context of cross-sectoral sports clusters, CSPs were rather formalized whereas overall networks tended to be informal (Gerke et al., 2018).

Managing CSPs effectively is essential to reach the desired outcomes of the partnership. Previous research has identified improvements to program and service quality and operations and enhanced community presence (Misener & Doherty, 2013) as well as stronger organizational resilience (Wicker et al., 2013a) as relationship outcomes that can be achieved with IORs. The achievement of these outcomes is predicted by management skills such as operational competence (Misener & Doherty, 2014), communication structure, partnership visibility, and task management (Hermens et al., 2019) as well as a shared vision and pre-existing relationships (Lefebvre et al., 2022).

All in all, the literature review shows a broad range of studies on IORs and CSPs in sports. While previous research has provided insights into the drivers, challenges, management processes, and outcomes of partnerships, most studies have either focused on single aspects of the relationship or investigated several partnerships without taking the specificities of the partner organizations into account. Especially partnerships between non-profit sports clubs and commercial sports providers have been mostly neglected, apart from Wicker et al. (2013b) and Vos and Scheerder (2014) who provided quantitative evidence on the extent of these CSPs and identified selected drivers of the partnerships. We address this research gap by investigating CSPs between a non-profit boxing club and its commercial boxing partners holistically, meaning from preconditions to management processes to outcomes.

Theoretical Framework

The present study focuses on CSPs between non-profit sports clubs and commercial sports providers. CSPs are defined as

> " … voluntary collaborative efforts of actors from organizations in two or more economic sectors in a forum in which they cooperatively attempt to solve a problem or issue of mutual concern that is in some way identified with a public policy agenda item." (Waddock, 1991, pp. 481–482).

Bryson et al. (2006) developed a framework for understanding CSPs, which provides a holistic view of the initial conditions, processes, structures, contingencies and constraints, and outcomes and accountabilities of partnerships (see Figure 1). Based on this framework and previous literature, Bryson et al. (2006) develop 22 propositions for the design and implementation of CSPs. In terms of forming CSPs, Bryson et al. (2006) propose that the formation of CSPs is affected by the competitive and institutional environment, potential sector failure, and the pre-existence of networks. In the

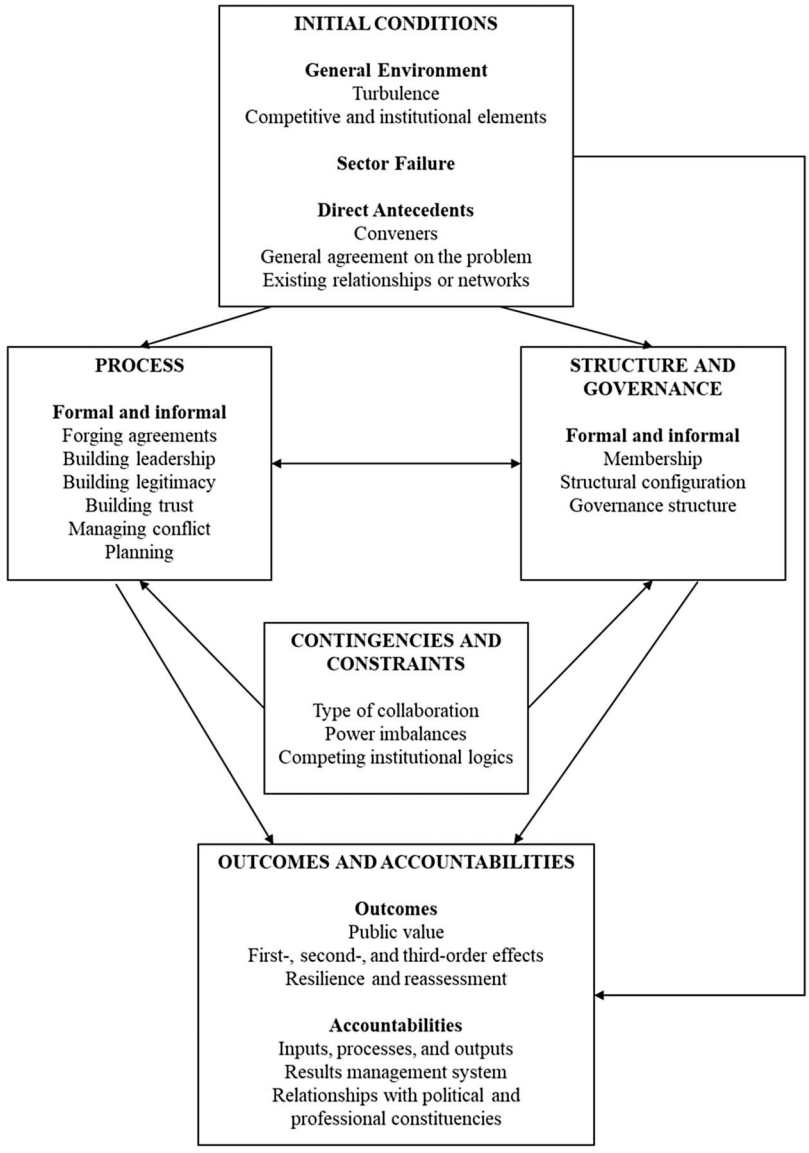


Figure 1 . Framework for understanding cross-sector collaborations (Bryson et al., 2006, p. 45).

process and structure dimensions, Bryson et al. (2006) stress the importance of both formal and informal arrangements for successful CSPs. Process, structure, and governance of CSPs are also affected by contingencies and constraints, such as collaboration type, power imbalances, and competing institutional logics. Finally, Bryson et al. (2006) propose that CSPs are most likely to create value when they build on the partner's self-interest, create positive effects, and are resilient and engage in regular reassessments. We use these propositions by Bryson et al. (2006) to investigate if they apply also to CSPs in sports.

Apart from defining the setup of CSPs, we base the study on a theory to define the perspective from which the partnership is analyzed. A systematic review by Misener et al.

(2022) identified a wide range of theoretical approaches that have been used in the investigation of IORs in sports, including transaction cost economics, resource dependency theory, network theory, strategic choice and management, stakeholder theory, and institutional theory. The current study utilizes the strategic choice perspective which posits that organizations enter relationships to increase their competitive situation in the market (Barringer & Harrison, 2000) and to achieve their organizational mission (Misener & Doherty, 2009). While previous studies utilizing the strategic approach have often looked at IORs as organizational capacities (Misener et al., 2022), we focus more on the initiation of CSPs as a strategic choice for the club. The assumption is that non-profit sports clubs enter partnerships with commercial sports providers to decrease direct competition, achieve a competitive advantage over other clubs, and achieve their organizational goals. As previous research has not yet looked explicitly at partnerships between non-profit sports clubs and commercial sports providers, our study takes a rather exploratory approach using a case study of a non-profit sports club with several CSPs with commercial sports providers.

Methodology

To answer the research questions, we conducted a case study at the organizational level. According to Yin (2018), case study research is favorable when the research questions are "how" or "why" questions, the control of researchers over the events under study is limited, and the phenomenon under study is contemporary. As all three conditions apply to the current study, the case study design was chosen. At the heart of our case was a non-profit boxing club, located in a mid-sized community in Western Germany, that entertained multiple CSPs with commercial boxing clubs. The specific case was selected as it presented a good opportunity to identify pitfalls and success factors in CSPs as one of the CSPs of the club was successful (started in 2019 and still running in 2020), while another partnership recently failed (started in 2017, concluded beginning of 2020). Data sources to analyze the case included interviews, document analysis, and an in-person survey. This data triangulation approach using several data sources was chosen to check for consistency between the data sources, add information on the organizational structures of the partner organizations, and provide additional insights into the outcomes of the relationships from different perspectives.

Table 1 . Characteristics of interview partners.

Interview	Main organization	Position
I1	Club	President
I2	Club	Coach
I3	Commercial partner1/ club	(Head) Coach
I4	Club	Board member
I5	Club	Coach
I6	Commercial partner1	Athlete
I7	Commercial partner1	Chief coach

Data collection

Before data collection, ethical approval was sought by the university board to adhere to the ethical standards of case study research (Yin, 2018). The main data source was semi-structured interviews with officials, coaches, and athletes both from the non-profit sports club (hereafter: club) and one partner organization (successful partnership; hereafter: commercial partner1). Unfortunately, no interviews could be conducted with officials from the recently failed partnership (hereafter: commercial partner2). All in all, $n = 7$ interviews were conducted, ranging from approximately 20 minutes to 60 minutes (see Table 1). The number of interviews was relatively low as the number of individuals involved in the partnerships was rather small. However, it can still be assumed that data saturation was reached as no additional themes and information came up in later interviews (Schreier, 2012).

Interviews were conducted either in person or via telephone between March 5, 2020, and May 5, 2020. All interviews were transcribed verbatim, and transcripts were sent to the interview partners to ensure correct recollection of interviewees' perceptions and to increase internal validity (Schreier, 2012). Interviews were held in German, which is the native language of both the interview partners and the authors. Selected quotes were translated into English and are presented in the results section.

Documents were collected from the social media channels of the non-profit sports club and both partner organizations (Instagram pages, Facebook pages), the homepages of all organizations involved, and local newspaper articles. This resulted in $n = 59$ documents that were included in the analysis. Internal documents such as written contracts, meeting minutes, or internal communication were not available. The documents provided background information on the partner organizations and served as a consistency check for the interview data.

Lastly, data were collected through an in-person survey of the club's athletes involved in the competition team. The competition team was chosen as the partnerships aimed at offering sporting opportunities for competitive athletes and thus these athletes were directly affected by the partnerships and could provide information on the outcomes from their perspective. The questionnaire was filled out by $n = 19$ athletes, which is a full sample as all members of the competition team completed the survey. Athletes under the age of 18 years handed in a written parental consent form before completing the survey. An overview of data sources and their relevance in answering the research questions is presented in Table 2.

Table 2 . Data sources and their relation to the research questions.

Research question	Data source
RQ1	Interviews, documents
RQ2	Interviews, athlete survey
RQ3	Interviews

Operationalization

Before conducting the interviews, an interview guideline was developed. Questions were based on the framework by Bryson et al. (2006) and aimed at the initial conditions, processes, structure and governance, contingencies and constraints, and outcomes and accountability of the partnerships. Questions were asked for both partnerships separately. Additionally, questions were included on the main management competencies required for a successful partnership from the interviewees' perspectives.

The in-person survey was conducted using a questionnaire, which contained three parts. The first part aimed at assessing the awareness and usage of the partnerships. The second part of the questionnaire assessed the importance and satisfaction with several aspects of the club and the importance of the partnerships for these aspects. The items were based on previous research by Nagel et al. (2006). The questionnaire concluded with questions on the socio-demographic background of the athletes.

Data analysis

Data were analyzed using qualitative content analysis (Schreier, 2012) and descriptive statistics. The interview data were coded both inductively and deductively. Categories were derived deductively from the framework by Bryson et al. (2006). Additionally, the category "management competencies" was introduced to reflect research question 3. Sub-categories were developed inductively based on the themes coming up in the interviews. Pilot coding was conducted on the first interview with the president of the boxing club as this interview presented the most extensive information.

Survey data were analyzed using the software SPSS 28. Descriptive statistics were computed to measure the extent of athletes' perceptions of the partnership outcomes in terms of satisfaction and importance. Mean and standard deviation values were computed and are reported in the following section (see also Table 3).

Results

Initial conditions

The interviews revealed four sub-categories as initial conditions of the partnerships: (1) organizational size of the partners, (2) reasons for entering the partnership, (3) prior contact/ base of trust, and (4) external conditions.

Organizational size referred to the number of members of the club and commercial partner1, the number of coaches, and the number of sports offered. The president of the club pointed out that entering CSPs requires a larger organization: "And only the bigger clubs can pull it off. I would say a bigger club for a boxing club – we are a bigger club with 150 members. That is okay." (I1). Moreover, both organizations (of the successful partnership) had a relatively large number of coaches in their organizations who were responsible for different sports, respectively different levels of competition. Both partner organizations pointed out their coaches as the main capacities on their homepages as the document analysis revealed. Lastly, at the point of the study, the club was a single-sport club whereas the commercial partner was a multisports club offering different types of combat sports.

Table 3 . Descriptive results on the importance of the partnership with commercial partners (athletes' perspective; $n = 19$).

Statement	Mean	Standard Deviation
Achievement of sporting success on national level	4.00	1.03
Promotion of competitive sports	4.22	.81
Promotion of talented children and adolescents	4.06	.80
Diverse offers in grassroots sports	3.80	.86
Quality of sports offers	4.22	.81
Competent club leadership	4.00	.94
Dedicated club leadership	4.18	.81
Low membership fee	3.72	.96
Favorable price-performance ratio	3.88	.81
Dedicated coaches	4.41	.80
Competent coaches	4.47	.80
Club image	4.12	.89
Public attention for the club	4.06	.83
Sense of community within the club	4.33	.84

Regarding the reasons for entering the partnerships, the club saw the partnerships as an opportunity to recruit promising athletes. Both partnerships were entered as the club saw potential in the athletes of the commercial partners as the president of the club pointed out: "Because he (*owner of commercial partner2*) had quite good athletes and we came together at different sparring events (…) and recognized the potential of the competitive athletes, that he had. And then we said 'Okay, that could be something" (I1). The reasons for entering the partnership from the commercial perspective were more business oriented as the commercial partner1 saw the partnership as a way to broaden the commercial club's service and thus strengthen the product portfolio. Thus, it was more of a business decision to retain members by offering additional services.

The start of the partnerships was facilitated as in both partnerships, there was prior contact between the president of the club and the boxing coach of the respective commercial partner. In the case of the successful partnership, this prior contact led to the head coach (I3) being active both in the club and in the commercial partner organization (commercial partner1). This existing level of trust enabled communication from the start. Moreover, the level of trust was mentioned by other board members as they had high trust in their president and thus followed him in the decision to enter the partnerships. Thus, the decision to enter the partnerships were –

in the case of the club – the sole decisions of the president, as one board member explained:

> "No, our involvement (*the club's board*) was relatively low. (…) But it was similar that our president said: 'We are now cooperating with them, that is a good guy, I have known him for a long time.' And the board is always of one opinion and trusting on what the president says." (I4).

Lastly, external conditions played a role in the decision to enter the partnerships. However, external conditions were only mentioned as side points with little emphasis by the interview partners. External conditions that were mentioned included a lack of training partners near the club and the high esteem of the club in the boxing community, which was seen as an attractive factor for the commercial partners.

Process

Questioned about the process of the partnerships, the interview partners mentioned (1) the communication channels, (2) the organization of training and competitions, and (3) personal responsibilities as important aspects.

In the case of the successful partnership, communication between coaches of both partner organizations was undertaken via telephone, e-mail, and messengers (WhatsApp). All coaches stressed the close communication between each other as one important aspect of the partnership. Communication between athletes and coaches was also described as close, with direct contact even with athletes from the commercial partner. When it came to administrative tasks and communication between commercial partner1 and the nonprofit boxing club, the head coach (I3) functioned as a mediator. Direct communication on the management level between the partner organizations only occurred regarding advertising rules as posting competition results falls under the regulations of the sports federations and thus commercial partner1 was dependent on the club's expertise on how to correctly post the sporting titles.

In the case of the successful partnership, the organization of training sessions was structured with weekly joint training sessions at the location of the club which was led by the head coach (I3). All other training sessions were held separately. Training sessions of the competition team of the club were video recorded and sent to the head coach who then gave feedback and was thus always updated on the athletes' development. Besides close communication, this joint organization of training was another important aspect of keeping the partnership successful. This was also mentioned by the athlete of commercial partner1 who described the integration into the competition team as easy and uncomplicated despite the little time spent together. Another indicator of the importance of joint training sessions was that in the case of the failed partnership, the lack of joint training sessions was explicitly stated as a disadvantage: "But otherwise the training hardly overlapped at all. So you knew that the athletes existed. We also tried to form a team out of all the athletes, which did not turn out well." (I4). Apart from the organization of training, the partners had to organize competitions with their athletes. In both partnerships, coaching at competitions was done jointly with one coach of the club and one coach of the commercial partner. Athletes from the commercial partners were fully integrated and treated the same as athletes from the boxing club.

Lastly, personal responsibilities were mentioned in the process of the partnerships. This referred to the shared responsibility of the coaches regarding the competition team and a clear separation from all other athletes. The successful partnership was mainly managed by the coaches and the president of the club whereas there was little to no involvement of the management level of the commercial partner1. This clear division of responsibilities was seen as beneficial by all interview partners

and pointed out as important. The importance of clear responsibilities was also reflected by the organization of starting licenses, which was managed differently in the successful and failed partnerships. In the case of the successful partnership, the starting licenses were held in the responsibility of the club whereas, in the failed partnership, the starting licenses were kept by the commercial partner2.

Structure and governance

The partnerships between the club and the commercial partners relied on (1) formal and (2) informal arrangements in the set-up of structure and governance.

Formal arrangements referred in both partnerships to membership arrangements of athletes and coaching licenses. All athletes from the commercial partners had to become a member of the club to enter competitions. This was seen as a basic element for all interview partners. Moreover, the board members and coaches of the club stressed the importance of adequate coaching licenses as a prerequisite for the partnerships. Surprisingly, there were no further formal arrangements in the successful partnership whereas the failed partnership was based on a contractual agreement with clear obligations. These obligations included participation in competitions by the commercial partner2's athletes. The contract was renewed automatically on an annual basis.

The successful partnership was based solely on informal arrangements which were negotiated between the head coach and the club president. This was beneficial especially for commercial partner1 as the level of trust and the mediating role of the head coach facilitated communication quite a lot:

> "What was practical was that P. (*head coach*) is active as a coach in the club from the beginning and also with us and it was very uncomplicated in terms of coordination and communication because he was responsible for the boxing session in both organizations anyway. So no one had to be informed because he was present in both." (I7).

This high level of trust led to the fact that even the informal arrangements of the partnership were communicated via telephone, which was the only involvement of the commercial partner in the set-up of the partnership.

Contingencies and constraints

During the process of the partnerships, some ups and downs were experienced. These negative factors – in terms of Bryson et al.'s (2006) model: constraints – referred to (1) personal conflicts, (2) lack of athletic success, and (3) competing institutional logics. These constraints were specially mentioned in the context of the recently failed partnership. Contingencies, meaning factors addressing these constraints, were (4) the role of the federation and other clubs.

Personal conflicts were described mainly as insults to the club management by the commercial partner2 of the failed relationship. The personal relationship, which was previously described as trusting, slowly went downhill and ended in personal conflicts between the commercial partner, athletes, and club management. The trigger was a conflict about a poorly packed competition gear bag, which ultimately led to the termination of the partnership as this came with penalty costs for the club.

Another factor that triggered the negative trend in the partnership was the lack of athletic success. The athletes from the commercial partner, who were initially very successful, lacked success in the later stages of the partnership, which contributed to the tense relationship between the partners. One coach of the boxing club illustrated this as follows: "The successes were missing. There was no significant success. And that's why I think that it went downhill. Let alone because he recognized that we are fetching the victories and not him." (I2). Moreover, the lack of athletic success could also lead to the dismissal of

athletes without the termination of the partnership. According to the president of the boxing club, this scenario happened three to four times. Thus, the lack of athletic success could lead both to the termination of partnerships and the termination of athlete involvement.

A constraint of both partnerships was the competing institutional logics of the non-profit boxing club and the commercial partners, but also of the clubs and the federation. One specific feature of the German boxing regulations is the ban on joint work between professional boxers and amateur boxers. This was pointed out as a constraint by both the boxing club and commercial partner1 as the clubs strived for maximum training opportunities for their athletes, which was restricted by the federation's ban. This also constrained the partnerships as they had to comply with this regulation and limited the pool of potential partnerships. Moreover, while the non-profit club was volunteer-oriented with a focus on athletic success and fun, both commercial partners were for-profit organizations that had to keep an eye on the financial balance. One coach of the club described it as follows:

> "The thing is with us, we work voluntarily. And we don't earn any money with it. And our benefit is fun. (…) And then, of course, he (*head coach of commercial partner2*) also did it commercially, he made money with it." (I2)

The competing institutional logics also led to frustration as the benefit that the commercial partner2 received was seen to be higher than for the club. It was specially mentioned in the context of athlete turnover and the imbalance in financial investment and athletic success. A high athletic turnover in the commercial partners meant more effort for the club as new starting licenses had to be applied for and old starting licenses had to be decommissioned. Moreover, a higher athletic turnover could also lead to lower accountability of the athletes, which led to missed competitions and penalty fees for the boxing club. This development together with the declining athletic success led to a negative cost–benefit ratio for the club and constrained the partnership.

To address these constraints, two institutions were mentioned to aid in problematic situations. For one, the boxing federation played a role as it functioned as a disciplinary institution. The final measure would be the withdrawal of the coaching license, which would hinder the commercial partners from offering and marketing their services. This also stressed the importance of existing coaching licenses as common ground in the partnerships. Lastly, other boxing clubs played a role as the club transferred the starting licenses of athletes from failed partnerships to other clubs close to the athletes to keep athletes in the competition system. Thus, athletes had the chance to keep competing despite the failed partnership and other clubs filled the void that the partners left behind.

Outcomes and accountabilities

The outcomes of the partnerships were (1) image enhancement, (2) athlete recruitment and sporting success, and (3) training quality.

The outcomes of the partnership differed from the different perspectives. The most important outcome for commercial partner1 was image enhancement. The victories of athletes that competed through the club could be promoted via social media, i.e. through Instagram and Facebook pages. This was seen as beneficial as it created a "round image" and highlighted the opportunities that the commercial club could offer to its customers.

All partner organizations mentioned the benefit of the recruitment of new athletes, respectively customers. From the perspective of the commercial partner1, the partnership widened the target group for potential customers as people with a competitive motive were also attracted to start boxing in the commercial club. From the perspective of the club, the partnership with the commercial partners

offered the opportunity to recruit especially female athletes. The reason for this was that women and girls started with boxing rather for fitness motives than for competitive motives as explained by the head coach:

> "What I see here in the competitive field in Germany is very interesting. Many women and girls want to try and do this. And in K. (*commercial partner1*), this has a lot to do with fitness, but also great potential for the competitive field. And what I say is: 'Okay, I see this right away in training – what I see is very fit and has a great potential'. What I see in the girls and women in K. are at least six German champions if they want to box." (I3).

The recruitment of new athletes was also reflected in spatial expansion, which was mentioned both by representatives of the club and the commercial partner1. As the president of the club explained:

> "Yes, of course, the topic of moving into the field always plays an important role in sports today. So if you want to continue to exist, you have to do something, you have to go into the wider area. And the clubs that don't go into the area, that don't attract athletes in the wider field, fall behind at the end of the day." (I1).

Apart from the potential of new successful athletes, the partnerships increased the club's existing sporting success. This was reflected by more sporting medals achieved in competitions and a wider age and gender range covered in competitions by the club. Moreover, the integration of athletes from other organizations into the training regime was seen as beneficial to increase the performance of the club's athletes due to different fighting styles and different backgrounds.

From the perspective of athletes, the opportunity to participate in competitions was also the most important outcome. As one athlete pointed out, participation in amateur competitions is only feasible through non-profit boxing clubs. Experience in amateur competitions was described as important to prepare for professional fights, thus this opportunity was seen as a strong benefit from the athletes' perspective. This was partly reflected by the survey of the competition team of the boxing club. While almost three-quarters of the athletes agreed with the statement, that the partnerships were important for the achievement of sporting success on a nationwide level ($M = 4{,}00$), the agreement for other statements was slightly higher (see Table 3).

One further prime outcome of the partnerships for the club was the increase in the quality of training and the attraction of highly skilled coaches. Through mutual learning and especially the experience of the head coach, more quality was brought into the club and the other coaches could benefit from the skills and knowledge of the head coach. Moreover, the success of the athletes was described to be promoted through the multiple perspectives brought in by the different coaches. This coaching outcome was also very important for the athletes as the survey results revealed that the partnership was deemed most important for the dedication and competencies of the coaches (see Table 3).

Management competencies

Lastly, interview partners were asked about the most important management competencies that were required for the successful management of CSPs. The themes that came up related to (1) communication, (2) shared goals, (3) accountability, and (4) leadership skills.

The main management competence mentioned by the interview partners was open communication and trust between the partners. Representatives of both the club and the commercial partner1 pointed out that there should be no hidden agenda and a mutual understanding between the partners to keep the partnership effective. It was further stressed that failed communication would lead directly to problems and could endanger the partnership: "As soon as there is mistrust or someone has the feeling: 'Ah,

now he/she wants to outmaneuver me … ' As soon as this is in the room, the partnership isn't worth it anymore." (I7).

Furthermore, the emphasis was placed on mutual benefits and shared goals as factors for a successful partnership. Mutual benefits could relate to additional coaching resources, a larger talent pool of athletes, spatial expansion, etc. In terms of shared goals, it was stressed from the perspective of the club, that the main goal of the club – namely, the promotion of sports - had to be shared by the commercial partner to ensure an effective partnership. This was also seen as a critical success factor that could lead to the termination of the partnership.

Third, acceptance and accountability were related to respecting the responsibilities and rules of the partner organizations and not interfering in their operations. This was especially stressed in the internal context as all coaches and club/commercial administrators pointed out the clear distinction of rules and responsibilities between them. However, as the president of the club pointed out, the main rules were defined by the club and had to be accepted by the commercial partner. Moreover, acceptance was also mentioned by the athletes who emphasized the freedom of choosing the training location as one key success factor.

Fourth, leadership skills in terms of personality and motivation were stated by the interview partners as required management competencies. Both aspects were mentioned jointly as an inspiring personality was described as fundamental to motivate the involved partners to invest in the partnership. However, these personalities could also clash: "But still, one person always has to lead. (…) And when you have two alpha dogs, then it becomes difficult." (I5). Thus, these inspiring personalities could both facilitate a partnership or constrain it.

Discussion and Conclusion

The findings from the case study have highlighted various facets of CSPs between a non-profit sports club and commercial partners. On the first research question, the interview data have shown that the reasons why the partnerships between the club and its commercial partners were entered were rather opportunistic. A strategic approach addressing the competitive situation between both organizations or other external conditions was not evident. However, the partnerships were still entered into the organizational missions of the partner organizations, namely promoting sporting success (club), and broadening the range of services to attract a wider target group (commercial partner). Thus, it appears that the "purely" strategic approach focusing on the competitive situation (Barringer & Harrison, 2000) seems not to apply to non-profit sports clubs and their CSPs, whereas the organizational mission seems to be more central to the decision to enter such a partnership, as found by Misener and Doherty (2009). Relating this finding to theory, our findings show that the external environment seems to play only a minor role as a driving force, contradicting theoretical propositions by Bryson et al. (2006).

When it comes to how the partnerships were formed and managed (RQ1), the findings of the case study illustrate a slight paradox: while the process of the successful partnership was quite informal, the failed partnership was managed more formally. While this seems bewildering at first, evidence in CSP research in sports has shown that formal arrangements prove relatively ineffective in managing partnerships (Babiak & Thibault, 2008), contrary to the predictions by Bryson et al. (2006). In the present case, formal arrangements were employed to secure the club in case of a failed partnership as the level of trust at the beginning of the partnership was not fully established. The problem was though that the formal arrangements did not prove effective as the partnership declined. One reason for this could be that clubs have little sanctioning power as legal procedures in case of the breach of contractual agreements is resource-intensive in terms of time and

money, which presents a challenge for volunteer-led clubs. Thus, CSPs in sports seem rather fragile as they are based mainly on trust and less on formal agreements.

This trust between partners is established through open and constant communication, which has also been pointed out as an important aspect by Bryson et al. (2006). One form of communication, which was highlighted in the present case study, was digital communication via video feedback on training sessions as an effective tool to keep interaction between the coaches. As most clubs already use some form of digital tools in their internal and/or external communication (Ehnold et al., 2021), it can be assumed that clubs are relatively open to this and should be encouraged to foster their partnerships through communication, facilitated through digital aids.

In terms of the outcomes of the partnerships (RQ2), the interviews and survey data have shown that the club and its commercial partners point out some similar outcomes, while also emphasizing different partnership outcomes as important. The different outcomes reflect the different institutional logics of the organizations (Misener & Misener, 2017). While non-profit sports clubs generally strive for sporting success and therefore focus mostly on sports-related aspects, the commercial partners are profit-oriented and thus aim for business-related outcomes. These different institutional logics need to be considered in managing CSPs and in identifying common goals to strive for.

Shared goals were also one factor mentioned as important in the effective management of partnerships (RQ3). Moreover, the interviews have shown that a strong emphasis is put on communication and leadership to sustain a good base for the partnership. These findings confirm and extend previous research on the management of CSPs in sports (Babiak & Thibault, 2008; Misener & Doherty, 2013). The case study also revealed that the clear distinction between roles and responsibilities in terms of management, coaches, and athletes was important in managing the partnerships. Holding the partners accountable while at the same time respecting organizational boundaries (internal and external) appeared to be key to fostering trust and commitment in the partnerships. One facilitator, in this case, was the position of the head coach who functioned as a mediator as he was active in both partner organizations as a coach. The position of the coach could thus be termed as a boundary spanner (Slack et al., 2021) who facilitated communication and served as an indicator of trust.

Concluding, the current study has shed light on an example of how CSPs between non-profit sports clubs and commercial sports providers operating in the same market can be formed and managed. The case has highlighted the important role of trust and personal relationships while at the same time showing pitfalls in the strategic approach of identifying partners and fragile partnerships based on inefficient formal structures. These findings extend the existing body of research on CSPs in sports as they focus on partner organizations that could potentially be competitors but have chosen to be partners instead. These findings lead to implications for theory and practice.

Implications

Regarding theory, non-profit sports clubs and commercial sports providers do not seem to approach partner organizations strategically but rather partnerships are established based on prior contact. While the strategic management approach assumes that partnerships are entered to strengthen the competitive situation, this can be seen rather implicitly in the sports context through the focus on the organizational mission. This needs to be considered when studying non-profit sports clubs from a strategic perspective.

In terms of practical implications, clubs need to consider the different institutional logics in CSPs reflected in the partnership outcomes.

While the partners might strive for different organizational goals, a common ground should be found to formulate shared goals. In the sports context, the promotion of sporting success can offer an opportunity to bring partners together. This shared goal should be seen as a value that is created together and which constantly must be balanced and renewed.

Second, clubs entering a CSP need to communicate openly and constantly with their partners. One way to facilitate this can be the use of digital communication tools such as video feedback or virtual meetings to integrate the partners in training routines and/or management meetings. Another way to facilitate communication is the installment of a "boundary spanner", meaning a person active in both partner organizations ensures a constant communication loop.

Limitations and future research

Some limitations must be addressed. First, the sample sizes both in the interviews and the in-person survey are relatively low. No information could be gathered from the perspective of the partner organization of the failed partnership. Thus, some findings must be handled with caution, as pointed out in the results section. Second, the data collection took place right before the hit of the COVID-19 pandemic. Some interviews were conducted during the first lockdown in Germany, which might have impacted the perception of interview partners. No insights can be provided into how far the pandemic has impacted the partnerships as all questions aimed at the process of the partnerships before the lockdown. Third, as all data were collected on one case in one specific context (Germany), the findings of the study cannot be generalized to the overall population of non-profit sports clubs and their CSPs globally as the nature of non-profit sports clubs varies by context.

To extend the findings of the present study, future research should investigate CSPs between non-profit sports clubs and commercial sports providers on a broader scale. Comparing the results of the present case study with insights from other cases might shed light on unique and general features of cases. Moreover, quantitative research would be useful to investigate the relationship between partnership types, partnership drivers, and enablers and their effects on partnership outcomes. These insights could lead to more generalizable findings on CSPs in the sports context.

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